

SENATE JOINT RESOLUTION 17

By Akbari

A RESOLUTION to honor the memory of United States President Jimmy Carter.

WHEREAS, the members of this General Assembly were greatly saddened to learn of the passing of United States President Jimmy Carter; and

WHEREAS, President Carter was a man of deep faith, a humanitarian of the highest order, and a true exemplar of servant-hearted leadership as a way of life; and

WHEREAS, James Earl Carter, Jr., was born on October 1, 1924, in Plains, Georgia, the eldest child of James Earl Carter, Sr., and Bessie Lillian Gordy Carter, who together started a peanut business; and

WHEREAS, after high school, Jimmy Carter was a submarine officer with the United States Navy, serving seven years before returning to run the family farm upon the death of his father; he was thus a peanut farmer when he entered politics on the ground floor, achieving election to local school and library boards before becoming a member of the Georgia State Senate; and

WHEREAS, he served two terms as a state senator before being elected as Georgia's 76th Governor, a post he held from 1971 to 1975; in his inaugural speech, at a time when desegregation and civil rights remained tinderbox issues, Jimmy Carter declared that "the time for racial discrimination is over," and during his time as governor, he ensured that African Americans were appointed to public offices; and

WHEREAS, although his bid for the presidency initially polled at four-percent support from fellow Democrats, he toppled incumbent Gerald Ford to become the 39th President of the United States, serving in the country's highest office from 1977 to 1981; and

WHEREAS, his presidency was marked by his support of women, including his appointment of women to key positions within his administration and encouragement of his wife, Rosalynn Carter, to maintain a national profile as First Lady; he also championed an equal rights amendment to the U.S. Constitution, which would have provided legal protection against discrimination on the grounds of sex; and

WHEREAS, President Carter was one of the first international leaders to take climate change seriously; he installed solar panels on the roof of the White House and passed laws to protect millions of acres of unspoiled land in Alaska from development; and

WHEREAS, early in his term, President Jimmy Carter collaborated with Congress to fulfill his campaign promise to create a cabinet-level education department, and on October 17, 1979, he signed into law the Department of Education Organization Act, establishing the United States Department of Education; he also expanded the Head Start program to include an additional 43,000 children and families; and

WHEREAS, under President Carter's administration, the United States Foreign Service lifted its ban on gay and lesbian personnel, and in 1977, the Carter administration became the first U.S. presidential administration to invite gay and lesbian rights activists to the White House to discuss federal policy on ending discrimination in the federal government on the basis of sexual orientation; and

WHEREAS, his legacy also includes brokering peace between Israel and Egypt, inviting Egyptian President Anwar Sadat and Israeli Prime Minister Menachem Begin to Camp David in September 1978; the meeting resulted in the Camp David Accords, which ended the war between the two countries and garnered Egypt's formal recognition of Israel as an independent state; and

WHEREAS, in his post-presidency years, Jimmy Carter established the Carter Center to promote and expand human rights, leading to his receipt of a Nobel Peace Prize in 2002; he

also became a key figure in Habitat for Humanity, volunteering with the nonprofit alongside his wife beginning in 1984. He ultimately helped build 4,447 homes for those in need; and

WHEREAS, President Carter was deeply devoted to his family, and he always endeavored to remain true to family values of the highest order; and

WHEREAS, he enjoyed the loving companionship of his beloved wife of seventy-seven years, Rosalynn Smith Carter, who preceded him in death in 2023; together they were blessed with four children, Jack, James "Chip" III, Donnel, and Amy; twelve grandchildren; and thirteen great-grandchildren; and

WHEREAS, President Jimmy Carter leaves behind an indelible legacy of integrity and probity in public life, compassion and loyalty in private life, and diligence and dedication in all his chosen endeavors; and

WHEREAS, it is fitting that we should remember the bountiful life of this exceptional public servant and human being; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE SENATE OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES CONCURRING, that we honor the memory of United States President Jimmy Carter, reflecting fondly upon his impeccable character and his legacy of compassionate service.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.